Monday Nite Footballers Predictions

By Jim "Grand Dad" Nunnelly
Predicting Since 1970

Jim Nunnelly

Everybody's talking about it. Not about the demise of the Chiefs. Not about the falling-fast Mizzou Tigers. None of that kind of stuff. Black fans everywhere is talking about the possibility of a black-on-black Super Bowl come February 4. Now, of course, it is too soon to tell. And we all have to pass through Sunday's AFC/NFC championships.

Speaking of championships, New Orleans is looking good and they are ready to play the Chicago Bears. This may be a close one. The Saints must retain their high-energy approach to even have half a chance. And Chicago is expected to capture the NFC at home this week-end. On the other side, New England looks good, as they always do in late season. Talk about a play-off team. Those Patriots put on a show in December and January. And then, there's the Naptown Colts. They are just the opposite...beat the hell out of everybody in September, October, and November and come winter, they begin to play like the weak animals they are. But, everybody is still talking about them, anyway.

That's because history could be made this week-end. Odds are that we will have two black head coaches in the Super Bowl. Derrick Parker, over at Seven Oaks, thinks it just might happen. He states that it's all over the barber shops. Tony Dungy versus Lovie Smith. . . the thrilla in Miami. It just might be a black thing, this year. And with Prince performing. . . it will be one to remember.

If the Colts and Bears were to appear in the nation's greatest sports event, what a tribute to Martin Luther King, Jr. We would have overcome!

Brady To See Much Different Colts Defense

INDIANAPOLIS (AP) – The Indianapolis Colts' defense was bashed by opponents and critics for most of the regular season.

It suddenly figured out how to counterpunch in the playoffs.

By keeping opposing offenses out of the end zone and off the field, the once-maligned defense has taken Indianapolis right into Sunday's AFC championship game against New England.

"We're playing better," Coach Tony Dungy said. "We're tackling a little bit better. We've always had a pretty good rush in the long-yardage situations, but in the third-and-5, third-and-6, we've tackled the underneath throws a little bit better."

The dramatic turnaround has surprised everyone, except perhaps the Colts.

"I think we're playing consistently well for 60 minutes, and we're playing with an intensity that's been unmatched," former Pro Bowl linebacker Cato June said. "We're having fun doing it, and showing that all the stuff in the regular season doesn't matter."

Whatever the explanation, the improved defense has been able to get off the field quickly and played well enough to overcome two subpar games from two-time MVP Peyton Manning.

"It's not the 3-4, it's not the people, it's not the scheme," Dungy said. "It's doing your job on every play, and I thought that we did. The one thing that we've done well in this postseason is that we've played well on third down."

Split Personality: Grossman Shows Flashes Of Bart Starr

CHICAGO (AP) – After almost 500 throws during the regular season, half that many in practice each and every week, and three dozen more against the Seattle Seahawks, Bears quarterback Rex Grossman finally let one fly that kept a city from tossing him into the lake.

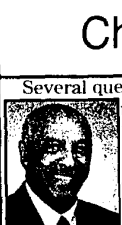
This week, anyway.

His teammates, taking their cue from stubborn Bears coach Lovie Smith, have bailed Grossman out a few times and supported him after every one.

Grossman must do it again when the Saints come to town -- with a much stronger offense and a healthy secondary to boot. Grossman knows the pickings won't be that easy against New Orleans.

"We're in the NFC championship, and we win one game, we're in the Super Bowl," Grossman said. "Two wins away," he said, "from having a ring on my finger for the rest of my life."

Chuck's Corner



Chuck James

Several questions following last weeks games! Is this the year for Manning? Can New England go to the Dome and prevail? Can New Orleans leave the comfort of their dome and brave the weather in Chicago and the Bears defense? These questions will all be answered on Sunday.

New Orleans at Chicago. The Cinderella Saints will face a real test here. Their best bet will be to rattle Grossman into making mistakes and hope McAllister can have another big game. **Prediction**: Chicago

New England at Indianapolis. A classic! The Colts defense has turned it up a notch but Manning can be stopped. New England seems to rise to every occasion. Even on the road they find a way to win. This will be no exception. **Prediction**: New England

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